

Menstrual Cramps

Menstrual cramps, also called dysmenorrhea, are throbbing or cramping pains in the lower abdomen that often occur just before or during a menstrual period. They may also be accompanied by lower back pain, nausea, headaches, or fatigue. Many girls and women experience menstrual cramps at some point in their lives.

For some, the discomfort is mild and manageable. For others, cramps can be severe enough to interfere with daily activities for several days each month.

Why Are Menstrual Cramps Painful?

During your menstrual period, the womb (uterus) contracts to help shed its lining. These contractions are triggered by hormone-like substances called prostaglandins, which are involved in pain and inflammation.

Higher levels of prostaglandins are linked to stronger uterine contractions and more severe cramps.

Types of Menstrual Cramps

There are two main types of menstrual cramps:

Primary Dysmenorrhea

- Common menstrual cramps not caused by another medical condition
- Usually begin during the teenage years
- Often improve with age or after childbirth

Secondary Dysmenorrhea

- Caused by an underlying medical condition, such as:
 - Endometriosis
 - Uterine fibroids
 - Polycystic Ovary Syndrome (PCOS)
 - Pelvic inflammatory disease (PID)
- Pain may worsen over time and last longer than a typical period

Symptoms of Menstrual Cramps

- Throbbing or cramping pain in the lower abdomen
 - Pain in the lower back or thighs
 - Nausea or fatigue
 - Diarrhea
 - Dizziness
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Treatment Options

Lifestyle Changes

- Regular exercise
- Stress-reduction techniques such as relaxation or stretching

Heat Therapy

- Applying a warm towel or hot water bottle to the abdomen can help relax the muscles and reduce pain

Medication

- Over-the-counter pain relievers such as ibuprofen or naproxen
 - These are most effective when started 1–2 days before your period begins
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When to Seek Medical Help

You should talk to a healthcare provider if:

- Pain does not improve with medication or self-care
- Cramps interfere with school, work, or daily life
- Your cramps suddenly become much worse
- You are over age 25 and experience severe cramps for the first time
- You have a fever along with period pain
- You have pelvic pain even when you are not on your period

Treatments for Severe Menstrual Pain

If your pain is caused by primary dysmenorrhea and requires medical treatment, hormonal birth control (such as the pill, patch, ring, or IUD) may help reduce or prevent cramps.

Always consult a healthcare provider to determine the best treatment option for you.

If you have questions or would like more information, you can contact us at **care@yarrow.com**.